

The secret joys of the dirty scissors brigade

From Page 1
me a whole week to get 4,000; you can't get any. They were 16-17; I rang up and asked him to get me some and he couldn't do it."

"The options are a better buy, they're only 5c."

"West Gold is a stock where you buy them and just have to forget about them. The options expire next October, but there's no one interested in West Gold now."

"Listen, if everyone is buying then you couldn't get them."

"What about A-Cap? A-Cap has drilled and they've found gold. Well, they reckon that if they had drilled down another 10 metres they would have found it."

"But it's always like that."

"That's another one that came good, you know. No one wanted them at 7c and now they're 33-34. They could still be good; Leo the tall Dutchman's been buying them."

Elise Pascoe

To be truffled with

I LOVE to eat well and I enjoy preparing food, so in my very private time what do I enjoy most, but to indulge in a little edible extravagance. And my current favourite dish is scampi with armagnac and a drizzle of black truffle sauce.

This recipe was taught to me by my favourite Italian chef, Angelo Pascucci. I was able to test it a few weeks ago with scampi from North-West Cape in Western Australia. They are snap frozen and flown to Townsville and are the first I've ever tasted in Australia. But you can

make this sublime dish just as well with fresh yabbies.

Gamberoni con Armagnac
6 scampi or yabbies, peeled and cleaned; 1 tbspn flour; salt and freshly ground pepper to taste; 1/4 cup olive oil; 1/2 cup dry white wine; 1 tbspn Armagnac; 3 tbspn Bechamel sauce; Tabasco sauce to taste; pinch paprika; 2 tbspn glaze de viande and black truffle.

Drench the shellfish in flour with little seasoning. Heat olive oil in heavy-based pan and fry shellfish until pink and opaque approx 1 minute each side. Spoon off half the oil and discard.

Pour in wine, heat gently and ignite. Stir in Armagnac, Bechamel sauce, Tabasco, paprika and glaze de viande. Whisk sauce over medium heat until reduced to a good consistency and the shellfish is just cooked.

Serve with a rice pilaf cooked in fish stock and scatter with fine slices of black truffle.

Accompany with that fine white wine, Puligny Montrachet 1982, La Truffiere, a superb French wine which finishes with a wonderfully aromatic bouquet of truffles — sweet, earthy, pungent — none of which is evident except at the end of the glass.

What a way to go!

Doug Anderson

The dirty scissors brigade

LOATH though I am to interrupt the vast and meaningful flow of information — both self-proclamatory and enigmatic — which circulates through these pages, the time

and the opportunity have come into confluence for a rare admission of certain rituals beyond orthodox boundaries.

At last it can be told. I am a secret collagist — one of the dirty scissors brigade.

It all started, doctor, when as an errant schoolboy, I developed a defence mechanism so insistent that concentration on homework became all but impossible.

Drifting through a copy of the Illustrated London News one evening, I compulsively picked up a pair of scissors, cut out a photograph of the Queen in Senegal, and snipped off her legs — replacing them, I hasten to add, with those of a far-from-elfin-dancer engaged in frenzied tribal dancing.

The result was a revelation. Never having been able to draw or paint to my satisfaction, I realised that at last I would indulge the surrealistic extravagances of my mind's eye.

I have never looked back.

Now, whenever time permits and I find myself alone with my scissors, I like to sit at my desk — stereo headphones on and a tall glass of Chateau Farouk in front of me — and slice into a pile of glossy magazines. There's nothing sinister about it, although privacy does help when it comes to dissecting men's magazines and removing certain (cough, cough) anatomical illustrations for my files.

Over the years I have cut up thousands of magazines — most of them donated by friends but some filched from household waste paper stacks awaiting collection.

The gutted and filleted shells are piled up in their hundreds on the front veranda (still too good to throw away completely) and the excisions stored for use in

pictures, postes, cards and letters.

I'm proud to say I have never purchased a card from a greeting card shop. Shop-bought sentiments are, to me, as sincere as a chain letter or an actress's kiss on opening night.

Some of the pictures I make from the cut-outs are about 80cm by 60cm and take 30 or 40 hours to complete depending on the complexity of their juxtapositions or, in the case of kaleidoscopic patterns, about half that time.

Swapping bodily components or transposing people from their natural environment to a radically different one is probably an extension of the blacked-out teeth, droopy moustache and crossed-eye school of hoarding defacement which flourished in pre-BUGAUP days.

I said there's nothing sinister about it but I must confess to a slight perversity which prevails from time to time. Not all the excised magazines remain mildewing on the front veranda. If ever you stumble across an inviting pile of glossy men's or women's magazines tied in string at a bus shelter, ignore them. They're as good as empty — disembowelled utterly.

Most magazines are pretty empty as it is. It's a rat act, I admit, but the temptation is too great.

As Bob Dylan said in *It's Alright Ma*: "Temptation's page flies out the door..."

Meg Stewart

Before the boogie boarders

EARLY before the boogie board brigade hits the breakers, diving into aqua sea-through, lost in watery wonderment, safe under a wave, corny though it seems, Bondi is

my solitary solace, summer refuge, safeguard against stress.

The beach at that hour is unused, cleaner, more cleansing, if you're not actually alone, it feels alone. Breathing, stretching, jogging, people go about their business, don't intrude.

Late evening is my other favourite beach aloneness time. When the sun has set leaving the water dark blue, tinged with left over rays, surfacing from foam effervescence to almost blinding, dazzling gold on water, a sure psychic soothe.

Easy to be lonely in a crowded city, less easy to lose the crowd. Take the last ferry to Manly and back, walk across the Harbour Bridge at dawn, catch the sunrise, do it both ways for real zen.

Wander through Nielsen Park, satisfying emptiness by night. Past the shadows of the giant magnolias, creamy flowers always so tantalisingly out of reach, sit on the high flat rocks at the end of the sand strip, gaze at a full moon. Swim out into the harbour.

Night swimming, however, has hazards apart from sharks. I once went pre-dawn skinny dipping at Bondi, walked out to a blaze of headlights and barrage of horns, every hoon in the world had suddenly converged on the beach-front.

Alone, truly alone, by yourself in the city can be alarming. Out of the city it's different. Being alone in the bush is natural.

Oliver-green brown water bounces over matching smooth gleaming river stones, bubble and fallen tea-tree blossom mingle in swift eddies round pockets of deep calm, the start of the Moongah Gorge where the tiny stream winds through the foothills of the Snowy Mountains.

Small skinks stare implacably from lichen-covered boulders, bright blue and lime green dragonflies hover overhead, each pool new delights, every bend tempts you further.

Solitude there is like diver's narcosis of the deep, you don't ever want to come back.

John Parkinson

For the sweet-juice freaks

WHEN it comes to enjoying such a wonderful social lubricant as wine, solitary imbibing is something generally frowned upon. You are either branded as selfish or a candidate for AA. The odd glass from the cask is okay, but to admit to consuming a bottle on your own is to put yourself beyond the pale in today's society.

I am usually generous with my wine. A great bottle of old white or a wonderfully mature classic red I'll cheerfully share. In fact, I'd rather share the experience.

However, when it comes to great sweet whites I have to admit to having secretly enjoyed the odd solitary indulgence. There seems something about that sheer assault on the senses that can come from a glass of a classic sweet white that perhaps should best be experienced in the privacy of one's own company.

For us sweet-juice freaks, the ultimate indulgence is a bottle of d'Yquem or perhaps one of those very late-picked, essence-like rieslings from Germany.

Unfortunately, all too frequently these wines are only available in full bottles, and my conscience still rebels at that level of personal indulgence.

I have no such reservations about half bottles, however, and recent developments in Australia have enabled me to indulge my private passion for the pleasure of the flesh of a sweet grape more often.

The current crop of half bottles of botrytised Australian sweet whites is quite mouthwatering. It seems inconceivable that as recently as 1980 only one such style existed on the market. Now there are at least half a dozen winemakers in Australia making what I regard as world-class sweet whites with the assistance of this dehydrating fungus.

Among my current favourite is the 1982 Mitchelton Botrytis-affected Coonawarra Rhine Riesling (about \$9 for a 375ml bottle). The Best Young White of Sydney Show last year and again the top-pointed sweet white at Sydney this year, this is truly a magnificent wine in the classic Germanic mould: crisp and fresh with wonderful essence like varietal fruit and a mouth-cleansing acid finish. It's my current indulgence wine whenever I can find the right occasion.

If I'm looking for something a little more baroque in taste then I lean towards the De Bortolis 1982 Botrytis Semillon (about \$10 for a 375ml bottle).

Put all those Riverina prejudices behind you — this is a great Australian sauternes style in any company. Wonderfully intense with rich complex flavours and a lingering quality which gives it an almost vicarious ability to please even after the glass is empty, it's a wine that easily justifies the acclaim and 26 gold medals it has won both here and overseas.

The francophiles may cavil at my selections. They don't have my mortgage — or perhaps the same desire as I do to enjoy the sweeter things of life as often as possible.

KEITH DUNSTAN dreams of stacks of hotcakes, dripping with syrup

Americans sure are normal enough to live in Adelaide

CAN ONE put a strange proposition about the United States? It is one of the most normal places on earth.

If you keep reading our newspapers and looking at television you get the idea that the United States is populated entirely by crazies, weirdos, junkies, psychotics and ambition-crazed politicians.

Actually returning from California I was startled at my old home beat, Toorak Road, South Yarra.

You wouldn't believe the number of odd-balls, gays, punks, girls with pale mauve lavatory brush hair-dos.

It beat the hell out of Santa Monica Boulevard.

Yes, the US gets a hard time and we are all guilty.

It is a country of 240 million highly exposed people, so something weird or eye-balling, as they say, has to be going on all the time.

That kinky story which will make page one is hard to resist.

Actually the US is filled with at least 230 million surprisingly normal people, about as normal as you would find in Adelaide.

You can't out-normal Adelaide.

The truth is I love America and I get back there at every opportunity. Thoughts about that kinky place come to mind.

They come with particular charm when touring Australia by car.

Does country food have to be that bad? Oh, the horror of the motels, the tray pushed through the slot with the greasy eggs, the three-ply toast, and instant coffee, which can only be described as one of the major crimes of the 20th century.

You don't get breakfast in a US motel — you go out for it.

Ask anyone who has been there. Breakfast at a roadside cafe is one of the glories of America where instant coffee is unknown.

It is beyond belief what you can get for \$2.

In nostalgic moments I dream of short stacks and long stacks.

A long stack is a pile of hotcakes akin to the leaning tower of Pisa dripping with butter and maple syrup.

And if you have any other order it is practically compulsory to have hash browns.

No, you wouldn't get them at the roadside stop in Gundagai. They are shredded potatoes, lightly fried.

More addictive than heroin, they are. And I'll tell you another thing about the cheap to the middle of the range eating houses, you get such wonderful friendly service.

Know why? The entire American catering industry is dependent on college kids.

They are working their way through university or whatever and invariably they are wonderful.

Honestly, Americans are friendly.

They may go in for muggings, and they do a whole lot of murdering, but at the same time they are remarkably nice to each other.

I have always had a theory that in the big hotels the bossman every morning lines up his staff and says: "Okay. You gotta be friendly, right? The first one of you not to wish a guest a happy day is out. Fired." So you do get wished a lot of happy days, but oddly enough I think most of them mean it.

Sure, the automobile is god, but the parking is easier over there.

Every business from the Bank of America down acknowledges that if they don't provide parking they don't survive.

Now I used to be a movie buff.

I'd go three times a week and that was because all the cinemas near us had hectares of parking space.

You never had to walk more than 20 metres to get to your seat, but there was more to it than that.

Not only are their cinemas about half the price, but you can go and just see the main feature that was advertised.

Here they are merciless.

They subject you to tedious shorts you wouldn't watch even on TV and they indulge in "no escape" advertising.

That is, they've got you in your seat so they subject you to cigarette sagas and slides about the new sofas in the local furniture house.

At home we've got a TV monitor to stop that sort of thing.

Where to go? Well, 99 out of a 100 people head straight for New York or Disneyland.

New York is interesting and I have never met the creature who didn't like Disneyland, but for heaven's sake, get them out of your system early.

If I were you I'd start off in Oregon then simply head west.

Now Oregon is just one big park and the Oregonians are the most ecology conscious people on earth.

They were one of the first to put a deposit on all cans and bottles.

You can go for hundreds of kilometres and never see a dropped can, not even a chewing gum wrapper.

All right, hire a car, get on a motor cycle or even better, ride a bicycle.

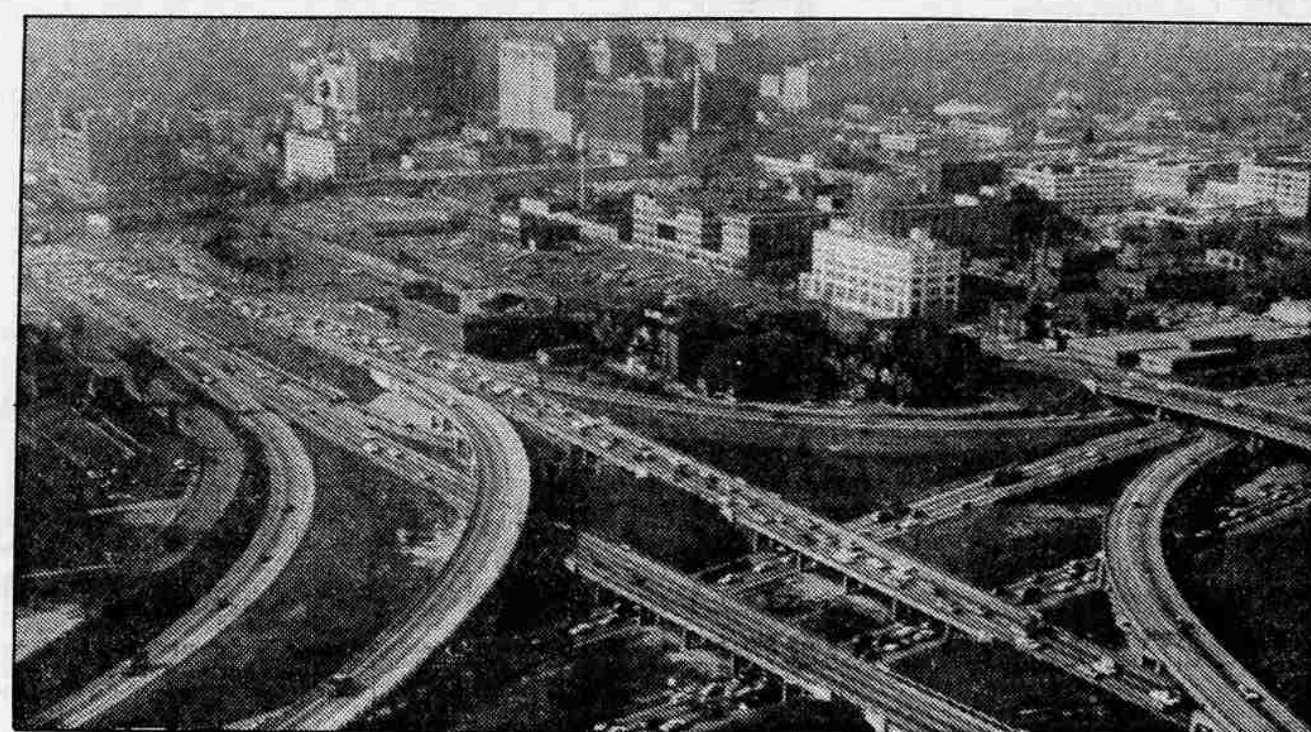
Out there in the north-west you can go for a 1,000 honest American miles (none of the metric nonsense there) and hardly ever get out of wilderness country, State and national parks.

If you read the papers and look at TV you believe America is a continuing trail of billboards, pizza houses, hamburger stands and factories.

Not true, this is the most beautiful country on earth.

I'm thinking of the pine forests and the urgent wild rivers of Oregon; long grass turning white in the wind on the plateaus of Wyoming; the quiet and sheer eternity of the Rockies in Colorado; the statue-like beauty of Monument Valley in Arizona which reminds you of every western you ever saw: the thousand and one lakes and the wild rice in Minnesota; the oceans upon oceans of wheat and corn in Kansas; the hills of Kentucky covered in white, yellow and blue flowers, and the old folk always sitting there on their verandas going back and forth on their rockers.

You will see moose, elk, antelope, skunk, squirrels, maybe a bear: camp, but don't go to those organised public



The car is god in the US, but the parking is easier.



A tired New York shopper stops for a hot dog.

affairs, where they have swimming pools, laundromats, juke boxes and cola stands, go to the State and national parks.

There you find camp grounds set right in the forests with maybe a few elk wanting to share your dinner.

And while giving you this solemn lecture could one also say there is no such place as America, because every State is different, not only different to look at but they speak differently.

You can get into places like Tennessee, Arkansas and Alabama, where frequently they speak an 18th-century sort of English and you need an interpreter.

Will you be mugged, raped, hit on the head? You could be wandering round parts of LA, Chicago, New York or Miami, particularly after dark.

But the advice is to get out into rural America and your chances of mayhem are no more serious than here.

I have done about 12,000km in the past 10 years, mostly by bicycle and the most serious event has been mosquito bites, but then I'm not very rapeworthy.

Yes, you'll find the US normal enough, except two things will drive you mad.

All the electric light switches are upside down and the plumbing is beyond belief.

You can go into 20 consecutive bathrooms and in each one find a different mysterious device on the shower.

You can get a shower with a single stick control like the joystick on a fighter jet.

By the time you have learnt to control it you have been scalded three times.

But never mind, the first 20 scaldings are the worst.

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